



Elasticsearch, in open source, needs no introduction. It is basically a search engine based on the Lucene library. At a point in time, it was the go to favourite of many, if not the majority of open source developers. The breaking news from the company came in early 2021 as it decided to inform its audience about Elastic License 2.0.

This, as per the company, simply means that the license allows the free right to use, modify, create derivative works, and redistribute. However, there are three limitations:

1. You may not provide the products to others as a managed service
2. You may not circumvent the license key functionality or remove/obscure features protected by license keys
3. You may not remove or obscure any licensing, copyright, or other notices (as published by Elastic.co)

In simple words, this means that neither the Elastic License nor SSPL has been approved by the OSI. Hence, the company is no longer referring to Elasticsearch or Kibana as open source. Elasticsearch is the greatest example proving how fast the world of open source is evolving, and how fast the existing business models are shrinking, while new ones are making their way!

“From the community perspective it was impacted in two ways. The first was that contributors, who worked for the same, were suddenly told that what they worked for was no longer truly open source. The second, keeping big and small players in mind, is the fact that the solutions they are developing now cannot be made public, keeping the announcements made by Elastic in consideration,” says Kabir.

Partnership with big players

This decade has been more about collaborations and mergers in the world of technology, and the open source vertical is not an exception.

Following this trend, to partner with a big player like Microsoft can be a big opportunity for startups and organisations already operating in the domain of open source.

Sanjeev explains, “If you are a services provider, there are opportunities available with Microsoft as the company has a specialisation in open source Linux and Kubernetes.”

In terms of ISV and IP opportunities, the world is witnessing innovation and launch of new solutions. Sanjeev, who gave an example of an assessment engine based on open source notes, “It scaled up very easily. However, the problem was finding customers beyond India. They leveraged the 60+ datacenters that Microsoft has.” He also gave an example of a sales nudge solution company, which helps the sales team to analyse deals and close them quickly.

Whether the solutions are for education, health, finance, or any other industry, big players, as per Sanjeev, can not only help scale the offerings across geographies but can also help make these solutions more secure.

“The core of the solutions that Microsoft offers are actually coming via partners. We are only providing them the platform. The solutions are coming through organisations which are based around the world,” explains Sanjeev.

The opportunity, as per him, is coming in accordance with the solution provided by the company. More than 60% of the solutions being offered are open source.

Partnering with big names also brings forth a question. Why is the value of open source companies so high? The answer lies in the consumer base that many of these organisations have. It continues with how brilliantly these companies are handling the complex layers of architecture.

“The conflict between Amazon and other companies is also one of

the reasons behind the high evaluation. There still exist companies which believe in hosting everything in their own server rather than a cloud,” feels Samir.

Then, why do developers work for free?

Samir answers, “Because you are using that tech for yourself. For example, if I am working on a project, I will want to use that for myself as well. I may want to build my UI using React and many such things. Once you start doing that and notice a missing feature, or find a bug, you end up fixing it and that creates an impact for the greater good.”

“The same also allows young and experienced developers to polish their skills. It’s almost the best CV you can have. It probably serves better than most internships that a developer could have. Where else would you have the opportunity to have your code checked by some of the best and brightest in the world,” he adds.

The open source industry is now undergoing a trend wherein the big players (the one’s providing cloud services) have also started facilitating open source stacks. Going by the trends, it looks as if every big company will soon join this race, and the same could lead to big changes in the open source Ecosystem.

“I don’t think there is space for any major changes. The community will always be there, whether it is from the cloud provider or open source companies. I do not think there would be any threat to communities or business models as such,” feels Samir.

Kabir adds, “I think this is the reaction to the recent license changes made in the world of open source.” **EFY**

This article, based on a panel discussion held at OpenSource India 2021, has been compiled by Mukul Yudhveer Singh, Business Editor, Electronics For You, until recently.